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THE INDIAN MUTINY AND THE RAILWAYS

Amidst Mutiny, War and Famine

1857 is remembered as a crucial year in India's history. It was the year of the Indian Mutiny, an uprising against the rule of the East India Company, which functioned as a sovereign power on behalf of the British Crown. Also called the Sepoy Mutiny or India's First War of Independence, it led to widespread chaos and death. There were atrocities committed against civilians by both parties, but in terms of sheer number, the casualties were much higher on the Indian side. India was thereafter administered directly by the British government.

The railways in the country were at a crucial juncture at this point of time. Having been launched four years earlier, the railways as a passenger transport system had more or less established itself by 1857, and its network was being expanded. The Mutiny changed the way things moved ahead. Military considerations had always been important, but after the Mutiny, they took absolute priority.

When the railways were first conceived, there were trade, military and social considerations. In fact, Sir Rowland, the first agent of the East Indian Railway, whose formal proposal for a railway system in India became the cornerstone of British railway policy, had in his report 'Introduction of Railways into India', submitted in 1844, given priority to the need for railway communication in India from a military point of view.

Stephenson had foreseen the economic, military and strategic importance of this new, speedier form of transport for securing the country, where the lurking danger of internal strife and external interference could